

CENTRAL GREAT PLAINS

A rolling landscape, once covered in a sea of grass

Forming a broad band through North America almost to Mexico, between the Rocky Mountains and the Missouri River, the Central Great Plains was once an immense, gently rolling prairie landscape that was dominated by mixed grasses for millions of years. Succession by trees and scrub was kept down by wild fires and grazing by native herbivores such as American bison, pronghorn antelope, and prairie dogs. The prairies were also home to a variety of reptiles, birds, and invertebrates, and many of these animals were exploited sustainably by nomadic American Indian tribes.

Conversion to agriculture

As recently as the early 19th century, this vast area was still covered by grassland. Today, most of the fertile land is given over to agriculture. Overexploitation of arable land in the early 20th century led to the environmental

and economic catastrophe in the 1930s known as the Dust Bowl, in which the topsoil was entirely lost from vast areas in a series of dust storms caused by drought and wind erosion. The land has mostly recovered sufficiently to support grazing, but the vast herds of bison that once roamed the prairies are largely gone, replaced mainly by domestic cattle.

A few pockets of relatively pristine prairie remain in the US and Canada, and in reserves such as the Wichita Mountains Wildlife Refuge in Oklahoma, surviving bison herds are protected. Even here, trees are few, and large vegetation is limited mainly to mesquite scrub and prickly pear cactus.



ORNATE BOX TURTLE

LIVING IN A BOX
The ornate box turtle is one of two terrestrial turtles on the Great Plains. They are named for their hinged lower shell, which can be clamped shut to protect the head and limbs from predators. However, many of them are killed trying to cross roads.

BECOMING A PEST
This beetle used to feed on a prairie weed, *Solanum rostratum*, or spiny nightshade. But when settlers planted another *Solanum* species, the cultivated potato, the beetle changed its diet and became a notorious crop pest.



COLORADO POTATO BEETLE

BOOMING MARVELOUS
The spring mating rituals of the greater prairie chicken are a new ecotourism attraction thanks to conservation efforts. Male birds compete at regular "booming grounds," making loud calls amplified by inflated air sacs on the neck.

PRAIRIE CHICKEN

30 million bison once lived on the Great Plains

Only 1% of the natural grassland survives

